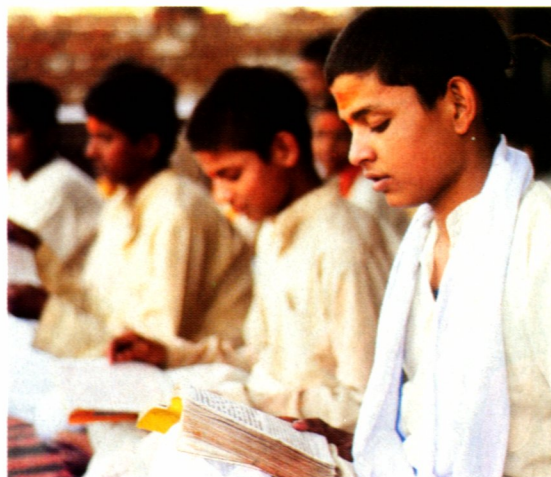




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THE SACRED AND THE MUNDANE: Students are taught the vedas and the puranas (right) as well as more practical lessons like tying their dhotis (above)



“I want to be a good follower of *sanatan dharma* (eternal dharma).”

SHANKAR LAL TRIVEDI, A STUDENT AT THE GURUKUL

■ By Farzand Ahmed

Photographs by Maneesh Agnihotri

Clad in a white kurta and dhoti, six-year-old Shankar Lal Trivedi is the spitting image of a guru and can play the part too. He can chant over 200 vedic mantras and *shlokas* non-stop and is well on his way to mastering Sanskrit. Brought to Shri Mahakaleshwar Tapobhum Vaidik Gurukul Sanskrit Vidyalaya after his father died, Trivedi is one of a 100 children from poor Brahmin families of Uttar Pradesh, who are going through the rigours of religious life at the school. Nestling in a remote corner of Banthara, on the outskirts of Lucknow, the Vidyalaya is a unique institution that prides itself on developing *karmakandi* gurus skilled in conducting vedic rituals. Patterned after ancient gurukuls, the school was started by Dev Chaitanya Bramhachari, popularly known as Guruji, in 1986. Studies here last for 15 years, at the end of which the *shishya* (disciple) attains the status of an *acharya*. It will be many years before Trivedi becomes an *acharya*, but in that time many more like him will have emerged, working in their own small way to sustain an ancient way of life. ■